



PERMITS · REGULATIONS · TAMPA BAY

The Tampa Bay Dock Permit Checklist.

Every agency, every fee, every deadline you need to hit before a piling driver rolls onto your property. Five agencies, one checklist.

5

Agencies your dock touches

10–16

Weeks, permits to piling

\$2k–\$5k

Typical permit fees



START HERE

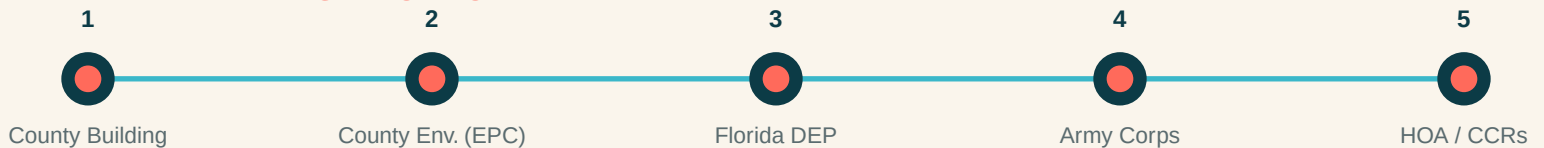
Read this before you file anything.

Every private dock in Tampa Bay ends up in front of four to five separate offices. Miss any one and the entire project stalls. This checklist walks each agency in the order they actually matter — county first, federal last — with the fees, timelines, and gotchas we see kill applications every quarter.

How to use this checklist

- Work top to bottom. Later agencies almost always require documents from earlier ones.
- Tick each row as you complete it. If a row does not apply, cross it out and note why.
- Keep a folder with every stamped approval — you will need originals at final inspection.
- Do not assume your builder pulled a permit. Ask for the receipt on the day they promise it.

THE FIVE-AGENCY ORDER





1

County Building Department

Hillsborough · Pinellas · Manatee · Sarasota · Pasco

FEE RANGE

\$1,800 – \$3,000

TIMELINE

4 – 12 weeks

The local permit that authorises construction on your property. Every Tampa Bay dock starts here.

- ☐ Confirm the correct office by parcel: Hillsborough Building Services, Pinellas Building & Development Review, Manatee Building & Development Services, Sarasota Development Services, or Pasco Building Construction Services.
- ☐ Order a fresh boundary survey (< 12 months). Old surveys get rejected. Budget \$800–\$2,500.
- ☐ Site plan showing dock length, width, height, distance to property lines, and mean high water line.
- ☐ Structural drawings signed and sealed by a Florida-licensed engineer for anything over 500 sq ft or with a lift.
- ☐ Product-approval numbers for pilings, fasteners, and decking. Miami-Dade NOA numbers speed review.
- ☐ Notice of Commencement filed with the county Clerk of Court once permit is issued.

2

County Environmental Review

Hillsborough EPC (Pinellas rolls this into #1)

FEE RANGE

\$250 – \$700

TIMELINE

4 – 8 weeks (parallel to #1)

Hillsborough EPC layers on top of the building permit. Cares about seagrass, manatee zones, and shoreline change.

- ☐ Seagrass survey by a qualified biologist if any part of the dock is within 100 ft of documented seagrass beds.
- ☐ Manatee protection plan referencing current Hillsborough / Pinellas MSA zones and construction windows.
- ☐ Turbidity control plan (silt curtains) for any in-water work.
- ☐ Confirmation that decking material meets EPC light-penetration guidelines (grated boards for wider than 4 ft).
- ☐ If in Pinellas, verify the county-consolidated permit already covers EPC-equivalent review.



3

Florida DEP (FDEP)

Sovereign submerged lands + state Environmental Resource Permit

FEE RANGE

\$420 – \$1,000

TIMELINE

30 days (exempt) · 6 – 20 weeks (individual)

State agency that reviews every dock built over submerged lands. Most single-family docks qualify for an exemption or general permit.

- ☐ Check exemption thresholds: "d 500 sq ft, "d 4 slips, single-family use, no boathouse, no fill.
- ☐ File the Notice of Intent to Use exemption online via the FDEP self-service portal.
- ☐ Sovereignty submerged lands consent form (required even when exempt from permitting).
- ☐ If over 500 sq ft or near seagrass, file for an Individual Environmental Resource Permit. Expect 6–20 weeks + biological survey.
- ☐ Save the exemption letter or ERP with your county submittal — the county will ask for it.

4

U.S. Army Corps of Engineers

Jacksonville District — federal navigable-waters review

FEE RANGE

No fee for Nationwide · \$100 individual

TIMELINE

4 – 8 weeks (nationwide) · up to 24 weeks (individual)

Federal review for anything in navigable waters. Most Tampa Bay canals connecting to the Bay proper qualify.

- ☐ Determine whether your dock fits Nationwide Permit 51 (recreational). Most single-family docks do.
- ☐ File the pre-construction notification (PCN) if the dock is over 32 ft long or in special aquatic sites.
- ☐ Include a plan-view drawing, elevation drawing, and location map with lat/long coordinates.
- ☐ Section 106 (historic) and Endangered Species Act consultation may be attached automatically — no action needed unless the Corps requests it.
- ☐ Individual Permit path: budget 3–6 months and an environmental assessment. Boat lifts and roofs often trigger this.



5

HOA & Deed Restrictions (CCRs)

The one that ambushes owners most often

FEE RANGE

Varies (usually \$0 – \$150 review)

TIMELINE

2 – 12 weeks depending on ARC meeting cadence

Not government, but functionally the strictest reviewer. Can shut a build down after construction has started.

- ☐ Read the current CCRs cover to cover before you finalise dock design.
- ☐ Identify the Architectural Review Committee (ARC) and its meeting schedule — some meet quarterly.
- ☐ Submit dock length, width, height, lighting colour, decking material, and any lift or roof for approval.
- ☐ Confirm setback from side property lines and from any neighbouring dock.
- ☐ Get the ARC approval letter in writing on letterhead. A verbal approval from a board member is not enough.

THE FOUR THINGS THAT QUIETLY KILL APPLICATIONS

Skip these and you restart from zero.

- Assuming the quote covers permit fees — always ask for the line item.
- Skipping HOA review — post-construction teardown is expensive.
- Filing with a stale survey — under 12 months old, every time.
- Ignoring seagrass on aerial photos — reviewers can see what you can't.

Want a licensed builder to handle the paperwork?

Most established Tampa marine contractors pull every permit as part of scope. Get up to three free quotes from vetted local builders who manage this end-to-end.

mydockguide.com/quote !'

This checklist is general guidance based on 2026 Tampa Bay permitting practice, not legal advice. Rules and fees change — confirm with the relevant agency before you file. © 2026 MyDockGuide.

